



More than
pretty words.

Profound, conscious
commitments.

VOW
adventure
KIT

V O W A D V E N T U R E K I T

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Published by Ceremonies With Lisa Press
Lisa Hunter and Ceremonies With Lisa, LLC
P.O. Box 1743, Durango, CO 81302 USA

www.CeremoniesWithLisa.com

303-842-4321

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And A friendly request:

If you think the Vow Adventure Kit would be great for a friend...

Please don't pass along the PDF,
pass along the purchase link.

Thanks!

www.CeremoniesWithLisa.com/vow-adventure-kit

Introduction



Vows are the core of your wedding and the heart of your ceremony. The purpose of a wedding is to formalize the commitments that you have already made in your hearts. Vows are these commitments. If you had just one thing to spend time on, and you wanted to maximize the benefit of having a wedding, you would spend time on vows. They are the root reason this big event *is even happening*.

Why are vows the most powerful place to put your energy? As far back as anthropology can study, there is evidence that we humans have a natural urge to mark significant moments with ceremony, and the process around this is called "rite of passage". The passage, the time before the ceremony, is actually the most powerful time. *It is the meaning that you make as you are preparing for a ceremony that makes the ceremony itself a profound experience.*

Vows are the ultimate opportunity to make meaning during your wedding passage. A conscious, intentional process to decide what is most important to the two of you, what you hold most dear. What do you want to keep coming back to? What do you want to follow through on that will create the kind of relationship you intend to have? Then translate that into commitments. The end result is a clear set of guiding principles to follow in your marriage and to consult as

as your north star. Imagine having this kind of tool in your married years to come. And made by the two of you, no less.

This Kit will guide you to create this tool. Over my many years of officiating, I've noticed that my couples love a good adventure, so I've created the Kit as a series of four relationship-deepening adventures. Two of the adventures are date nights! Because, yes, let's have fun as you're creating this powerful tool for your marriage.

And for the amount of time that you'll spend looking for a wedding dress or the perfect spot to have your wedding, you can also have a set of clear, conscious commitments to guide your married life to come.

If that's not worth your time and effort I don't know what is.

So let's dive in. Simply complete each adventure, then you'll see how it all comes together in the "Putting It All Together" section. Let the adventure begin!

Love, Officiant Lisa



Overview Of Vows

During the ceremony, first you'll:

Share "Why I Love You's"
(Optional Preamble to Vows)

How: Read from a card.

Then You'll:

Make Core Commitments
& any Surprise Commitments

How: Read from a card, or you can
repeat them after an Officiant.

Your Choice

This is an in-depth process. I recognize not all couples will want to create vows this way. If it excites you, then do it - you will have an amazing tool for your marriage!

Or, you may prefer to simply choose from pre-written vows. If so, then visit this page on my site for options: www.CeremoniesWithLisa.com/pre-written-vows and the password is "easyvows"

Scheduling Adventures

The four adventures guide you to create the vow elements in the overview on the previous page. Do a quick scan of all four adventures so you have a sense of time needed, then schedule in your calendar.

Plan more time than you would think. Each adventure process is meaningful, and you'll want time to reflect, rather than rush. Schedule the last adventure at least one month before your wedding so you have quality time for all.

adventure ONE

Write "Why I Love You's"

SOLO ADVENTURE



Why I Love You's



"Why I Love You's" are OPTIONAL.

Why I Love You's" are different from vows. They are declarations about why and how much you love your partner, whereas vows are the actual promises. These two go hand in hand though, as "Why I Love You's" are almost always shared right before vows.

There is a trend in the wedding world to give you tons of examples to "inspire" these kinds of words, but we're not going to do that here. Instead, we're going to draw out your real, authentic words - the ones that come straight from your heart and soul without need of other people's examples. You have something gorgeous and deep and true and profound to say to your partner, and it's already in there. Other people's words actually distract you from your real words.

The most powerful inspiration? Deeply feel your love for your fiancé. Write words from there. Forget about whether they are "amazing" or "well-written". All that matters is that they are real and they are YOU. Those are the most potent Why I Love You's that you could write!

How To

Write Why I Love You's

Step 1: You'll each do this adventure solo. If you do want to include "Why I Love You's" in the ceremony, you'll read them before vows.

Step 2: Go to a location that inspires you. Maybe it's out in nature, or where you first met or a spot that is special to your relationship. Or maybe it's simply in your own home.

Step 3. Answer the "Writing Why I Love You's" Questions on p. 12 and write on a separate piece of paper everything that comes to mind. Write until there are no more words.

Step 4: Do this once or as many times as you like. When you're ready, use the "Writing Why I Love You's" Creation Card on p. 13 to distill everything down into one or a few paragraphs.

Questions

For "Why I Love You's"

Rather than try to "write well", imagine your sweetie asking these questions and simply answer from the heart...

Things You Love

What attracts you to me? Makes your heart jump... makes you laugh? What do you admire? What beauty do you see?

How You've Changed

How have you changed as a result of knowing me?
What have you learned? What important things are you reminded of, just by being around me?

Real-Life Experiences

What important things have happened for us - milestones, trips, ridiculous moments, breaking points that made us stronger? What was important about these experiences?

Our Life Together

What kind of spouse do you want to be? What kind of lifestyle do you want to build & dreams do you want to fulfill?

Powerful Last Line

Wrap it up with words that hit home, to the heart & soul.

Why I Love You's Creation Card

Creation Card

Reminders

Remember there is no "right" way to write these
& you don't need other people's example

Other people's examples distract from your real words.

It's all in you. Feel your love for your fiancé.

Write the words that come from there.

Forget about whether your words are "amazing" or
"well-written". Or how long, short, basic or poetic.

Some people are more verbal than others,
and every style is absolutely fine.

All that matters is the words are real & they are YOU!

adventure TWO

Create Core Commitments

DATE NIGHT #1

IDENTIFY YOUR TOP THEMES



Core Commitments Date Night #1



IDENTIFY YOUR TOP 10 THEMES

The purpose of a wedding ceremony is to formalize and celebrate commitment, and vows are the commitments that you make to each other. But commitments to... what?

Some Interesting History

Back at its inception around 4,000 years ago, marriage was a straight-up business deal having to do with land and resources. It wasn't so much about vows as it was about a financial transaction. Crazy to think it had nothing to do with romance or a love relationship.

After that, and particularly when the church came into the picture, traditional vows (for better for worse, for richer for poorer) became the norm. They basically say, "Through thick and thin no matter what, I will be there with you". Which is a really powerful commitment, and for many couples still says it all...

In today's modern wedding world though, where we have moved into an era of marriage for true love rather than for business or pragmatic reasons, there is room to choose vows even more specifically. Core Commitments Date Night #1 will give you the opportunity to explore, as a couple, what you really want to commit to, then decide together on your very own set of Core Commitments.

Why It's Worth The Time

Even if you end up using a simple set of traditional vows, this adventure of exploring commitment options is relationship-deepening. What do we each prioritize ? Where do we overlap? Where do we differ and what commitments can we create that feel great for both of us?

It's also just good communication. There's a trend in our current wedding culture where couples write vows separately, each coming up with their own set of promises. Then they surprise each other during the ceremony with "I promise this and I promise that". It's romantic, as in "Ooh I wonder what he/she is going to promise me". But it misses an incredible opportunity: To decide your core commitments *together*. To make the **same** agreement. So that you then have a very clear set of guiding principles to follow in your marriage, and to always come back to as your north star.

To enter a partnership with a clear agreement about what is important is, well, powerful. You wouldn't enter any other healthy partnership without that. Why skip it for marriage?

Permission To Make REAL Agreements

This adventure also invites you to explore what you really truly want to commit to. There is so much assumption about what marriage vows are supposed to say. You'll have the opportunity to drop all that and consider what it really means to you. Rather than blindly saying

yes to commitments just because those are the commitments that everyone makes, instead discover the commitments that truly inspire you and that create an amazing touchstone for the two of you specifically. These may end up being the typical commitments that we hear at weddings...or they may be wildly different... or somewhere in between.

Alright, let's do this!

Check out the date night instructions on the next page and you're on your way to creating an amazing tool for your relationship!

How-To

Core Commitments

Date Night #1

QUICK PREP BEFORE YOUR DATE

Decide: When & where to have your date. Date "Night" can be any time that works with your schedules - night, morning, afternoon, etc. Scan the step-by-step pages to see how much time you think you'll need, then pick a context where you can have meaningful conversation. You can go somewhere or just stay in. Life is busy, and if you can, do try to set aside this time as a special little date for the two of you.

Print: Before your date, read through these Core Commitment Date Night #1 pages (p. 15 - 24) so you'll have a sense of what you'll do, then print the pages to bring with you on the date.

Make: Using the Mini Game Card page (p. 24), cut along the lines to make six question cards. Put them in a small bag (or sock, hat, bowl, etc) to "pick out of a hat" during the game part of the date.

Step-By-Step

Core Commitments

Date Night #1

STEP ONE - NOTICE

There are so many images, ideals & assumptions in our culture about the vows we expect to hear at a wedding ceremony. What comes to mind first when you think of what couples are *supposed* to promise each other? Write them here:

STEP TWO - TIME TO PLAY

First, set aside the assumptions in Step #2. Some may end up being your vows, but for the sake of exploration, take the piece of paper that they're written on and literally set them off to the side. Then say to each other, "I wonder what commitments will be OUR vows?"

And now let's play a game!

1. From the small bag (or hat, sock, etc) with the Mini Game Cards in it, reach in and pick one card. Discover what words and phrases the question inspires and jot those down on a separate piece of paper.

2. One by one, pick more Mini Card questions and share ideas until you feel done. Jot down more words & phrases in the space below.

If you want, you can use the list on the **Commitment Themes** page on p.23 to spark conversation. Or if you're inspired without needing commitment ideas, just answer from your heart.

STEP THREE - THE TOP 10

Now that you've jotted ideas, it's time to pick your Top Ten Commitment Themes and list them here. If you have less that's fine. If you're over ten, then look to see how some might be similar to one another and distill down. Let these percolate in the back of your mind, noticing which keep popping back on your radar as important, until it's time for Date #2:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____

Commitment Themes

I made this **List Of Commitment Themes** by going back through the vows of more than 100 of my couples and naming the major themes that recurred throughout. Notice which of these stand out to the two of you, plus any themes of your own that aren't on here. Or, if this list makes you feel overwhelmed, then ditch it and simply do Step #3 from your heart!

(These are in no particular order)

SUPPORT
SAFE HARBOR
SEEING WHO YOU ARE
FUN
HUMOR
ADVENTURE
DREAMS
GROWTH: PERSONAL
GROWTH: TOGETHER
TRUST
FRIENDSHIP
ACCEPTANCE
SPIRITUALITY
TELLING THE TRUTH
HOME
PATIENCE
FIDELITY
COMMUNICATION
FAITH IN US
FAITH IN LIFE
RELATIONSHIP SKILLS

APPRECIATION
LEARNING
BEING PRESENT
TEAM
INDIVIDUALITY
FAMILY
PHYSICAL HEALTH
EMOTIONAL HEALTH
EXPRESSING LOVE
BIGGEST FAN
CHORES
KINDNESS
PHYSICAL INTIMACY
SELF CARE
UNCONDITIONAL LOVE
SELF RESPONSIBILITY
TRYING NEW THINGS
FORGIVENESS
THERE NO MATTER WHAT
COMMITMENT FOR LIFE
COMMITMENT EVERY DAY

Mini Game Cards

Make Mini Game Cards

Print out the Core Commitments Date Night #1 pages, then make these mini game cards by cutting along the lines. Put them in a small bag (or sock, hat, bowl, etc) to "pick out of a hat" during the game portion of the date.

What commitments do WE want to make?	What's important to us? What do we value?
How do we want to feel many years from now? What commitments will support us to get there?	What will bring us back to what matters most? And what might be easy to forget?
How do we want to grow & what do we want to learn?	What will make our marriage strong?

adventure THREE

Create Core Commitments

DATE NIGHT #2

DESIGN YOUR CORE



Core Commitments Date Night #2



DESIGN YOUR CORE

Now that you've got a Top Ten list of Commitment Themes, it's time to distill down to Five Core Commitments. The number five is not a hard and fast rule, but if you can keep it to a number of Core Commitments that are easy to remember, then you can readily return to these guiding principles in daily life.

Your Very Own Marriage Guide

When you are done, you will have a body of Core Commitments to use as a touchstone in your marriage. If you are making big decisions, navigating challenges, or if you simply want to celebrate or touch back in with what is most important, consult the Core - it's your very own specifically-tailored-for-you marriage guide.

Vows Are A Living Document

The beauty of Core Commitments is that you can continue to revisit them on a regular basis. As your relationship changes and grows, your commitments will too. Start with the Core Commitments, then discover how they evolve over time!

How-To

Core Commitments

Date Night #2

QUICK PREP BEFORE YOUR DATE

Decide: Just like last time, decide when & where to have your date. Scan the step-by-step pages to see how much time you think you'll need, then pick a context where you can have meaningful conversation. Life is busy, and if you can, do try to set aside this time as a special little date for the two of you.

Print: Before your date, read the Core Commitment Date Night #2 pages (p. 25 - 30) so you know what to expect, then print them to bring on the date.

Make: Using the Top Ten List that you created during Date Night #1, make each Commitment Theme line into its own strip of paper by cutting along the dotted lines. Put these Commitment Theme strips in a small bag (or sock, hat, bowl, etc) to "pick out of a hat" during the game part of the date, just like you did with the Mini Question Cards for Date #1.

Step-By-Step

Core Commitments

Date Night #2

STEP ONE - GAME TIME!

One by one, draw Commitment Theme strips out of the small bag (or hat, sock, etc) and put each strip into one of three piles:

Pile 1: YES. This Commitment Theme has popped up positively in one or both of our minds/hearts repeatedly since Date 1, so it's a strong candidate to be a Core Commitment.

Pile 2: NO. Since Date 1, this theme hasn't stood out as Core, or we've realized it can be combined with another theme.

Pile 3: MAYBE. Either we're split in opinion about this one, or we're unsure about it.

STEP TWO - IDENTIFY THE CORE

Using Pile 1 and Pile 3, play with the Commitment Themes and distill down to five or less Core Themes that you will BOTH commit to. This may happen quickly or it may take some time.

Here are some tips...

- Each couple tends to have a core batch of themes - if you both commit to those, you feel confident the others will fall into place.
- If you're having trouble deciding, prioritize any themes that you felt strongly positive about between Dates 1 & 2.
- If there are any themes that one of you wants to make Core and the other doesn't, get curious if there is a way to tweak that theme so that it feels great to both of you.
- Scan for any themes that you think you **SHOULD** use. "Should's" are never true. These can be hard to nix, as there's some external messaging influencing you ;)
- If it just doesn't feel right to have five or less, then go with your gut instinct and have more.
- Vows are a living document, so you can always amend the commitments later down the line. What works now?

See next page for the final Step 3...

STEP THREE - WRITING YOUR COMMITMENTS

How do you want to say these commitments to each other? What captures the essence of what you are agreeing to follow through on? You can begin each with "I vow to", "I promise to", "With all my heart, I make the following commitments" or any words that fit your style. There is no "right" way to write commitments. Instead, connect with your sweetie and speak from your heart. The words that come are your most authentic commitments.

Together decide how you will say each commitment, OR you can each take your commitment themes and write the commitments in your own words for your sweetie to hear on your wedding day!

The image shows five identical horizontal lines arranged vertically. Each line is a solid brown color. At each end of the line, there are three arrowheads pointing towards the center of the line. The arrowheads are also drawn in the same brown color. This layout is intended to provide space for couples to write their wedding commitments.

adventure FOUR

Surprise Commitments

SOLO ADVENTURE



Surprise Commitments



Surprise Commitments are OPTIONAL

Surprise, or Personal Commitments are optional. Now that you've got your shared Core Commitments, you can still have some fun with commitments that your sweetie hears for the first time during the ceremony. These are not as essential as Core Commitments, but they are important promises that you want to make and that are not in the Core. You can add these before or after your Core Commitments, or weave them all together. Here are the types of themes for

Surprise/personal commitments

Funny, inside joke commitments

Sweet or romantic commitments

Quirky or unusual commitments

Heart/Soul stirring commitments

How To

Write Surprise Commitments

Step 1: You'll each do this adventure solo. If you do want to include "Why I Love You's" in the ceremony, you'll read them before vows.

Step 2: Go to a location that inspires you. Maybe it's out in nature, or where you first met or a spot that is special to the two of you. Or maybe it's simply in your own home.

Step 3. From your heart and soul, notice any silly, sweet, quirky, romantic, deep, poignant or special promises to make to your partner and that are not covered in Core Commitments. List them on the next page. Just as with Core Commitments, you can start with "I vow to", "I promise to" or whatever fits your style. *Note: If you plan to repeat these after an Officiant, rather than read from a card, see notes on length in "Putting It All Together" (p. 35)

Surprise Commitments List

Write as few or as many as you like!



putting it
all together

If You Want To Read From A Card

Partner 1: If you are including Why I Love You's, start with them. Next share your Core Commitments and any Surprise Commitments after Why I Love You's.

Partner 2 then does the same.

If You Want To Repeat Commitments After An Officiant

If you are sharing Why I Love You's, first read them from a card.

Next, repeat commitments after your Officiant. In prep, give your Officiant your list of Core and Surprise Commitments, or pick a set of pre-written repeat-after officiant vows at this link: www.ceremonieswithlisa.com/pre-written-vows and the password is "easyvows". If writing your own commitments, keep your wording as short as possible so it's easy to repeat. A good guideline for repeat-after phrase length is the standard traditional vows:

I, Charlie, take you Casey to be my partner.
To have and to hold from this day forward.
For better for worse,
For richer for poorer,
In sickness and in health
For as long as we both shall live.

See how short each line is? You want each line to be around this example length . You can have many more lines, but you want them to be short so that you can easily repeat. Practice repeating them after someone to see if they work!



day-of tips

Writing/Printing: If you're reading anything from a card, paper or vow book, aim to write or type it out in that format at least a few days before your ceremony. That way you're not scrambling last -minute and you'll also have time to get used to reading from it. It's also entirely likely you might want to add or change little things up until the last-minute, so leave room around the edges for changes.

Practicing: It's a great idea to practice reading or repeating after. Not so that you can be "perfect" during the ceremony, but because the more familiar you are with the words, the more comfortable you'll feel and the more you can enjoy yourself!

Vow Length: Once you've each practiced a bit, time yourselves to compare approximate speaking length, just to ensure there isn't a major difference - for example, one set of vows is 20 minutes and the other set is 2 minutes. However, do not obsess over having the exact same length. It's fine for vow lengths to be different, and this fits with having different styles. In comparing speaking times, you're just watching for major differences, and even then you can decide that's fine if it feels true to each of you.

Nerves: If you're nervous about public speaking, angle yourself slightly away from guests and toward your Officiant, plus keep steady focus on your partner and get lost in the world of your connection :)

Crying: If you have the urge to cry, go for it. It means you're feeling real emotion - allow yourself to have the most profound experience possible during the ceremony since this is a key event in your life. Don't miss it because you're worried about how you look. If you're worried about make-up, remember that ceremony photos are a small percentage of the entire day's worth of photos, plus you can touch up make up afterward.